

WinVDR

Nothing but formats

Swap two letters in the name of the previous software and you get WinVDR. However, barring the name, which is somewhat similar, both software are far apart in terms of features and user-friendliness.

Windows Video Disk Recorder (WinVDR) itself has variants that capture video in the AVI or the WMV formats. A better version, WinVDR Pro, captures video in DivX, WMV, AVI, MPG and MP4 formats.

The software has a mixer similar to VirtualDub that is useful to monitor, as well as control audio input levels. WinVDR provides an excellent way to capture video from the TV-Tuner card directly to a variety of formats in real-time mode. Generally, WinVDR supports any PCI-bus mastering capture device that uses the Brooktree (Bt848/878) chipset.

Stop conditions depend only on time; disk space is not taken into account. Hence, there's no way to stop the capture, in case of lack of space; all WinVDR displays is an unhelpful error message.



Make that Switch

A common misconception is that you have to sacrifice comfort when you switch to watching TV on your PC. Though this may have been true a few years ago, today, almost all TV tuner cards come with remote controls to enrich your experience. All you have to do is spend the first hour configuring the channels, then sit back and enjoy the show—with the added advantage of being able to pause live TV, and watch instant replays.

In fact, if you have the Windows XP Media Center edition, you don't even need to spend that first hour using the mouse. The navigation is designed to be used from a remote control, instead of a keyboard-mouse combination. It uses a simple list of functions instead of the standard Windows menus with buttons all over dialog boxes.

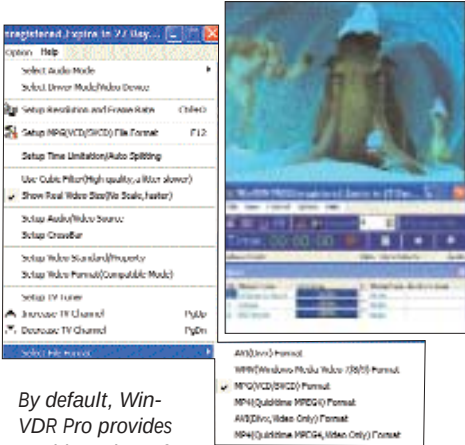
Just like Media Center Edition, most TV tuner cards bundle PVR software that work well with the bundled remote control. Though the software interface may not be viewable from a distance, most remote controls have neatly labelled buttons—just as TVs do—so operation is a snap. The sad truth is that most third-party software do not support remotes, and are a pain to use.



Apart from features such as preview and scheduler, it also has helpful little settings that let you prevent the screensaver and the power manager from running when capturing video.

However, you cannot pause and resume a TV signal at will, nor watch an instant replay—a point that went against it. Also, it records just one show at a time. Hence, you will have to narrow down your choice to a single show if your favourite television soaps overlap.

Price: US\$ 39
Web site: www.artech365.com



By default, WinVDR Pro provides a wide variety of file formats to save the captured video

- + Captured files named automatically based on system date or time; control audio input level
- Lacks real-time TV functions

End of the show

Well, as they say it on TV, that's all folks! We took you through 10 TV-tuner cards and five personal video recording software along with the big Media Center PC.

WinVDR and Cyberlink PowerVCR II happen to be the most commonly bundled PVR software. When pitted against each other and three more, in our tests, PowerVCR II won the battle hands down. Though WinVDR had unique features such as transcoding, Power VCR II powered further ahead in the race, thanks to the advanced recording parameters that let it reduce noise and enhance picture quality.

In the TV-tuners section, the cards from Pinnacle and Compro fought for the top slot. The Compro VideoMate TV Gold Plus, with intuitive software and nifty features, proved itself worthy of the performance crown. On the other hand, the Mercury TV Tuner Card had enough features that did justice to its low price and walked away with the crown for Best Value.

The HCL Beanstalk AQ265 Media Center PC is one big entertainment solution. Complete with speakers and an LCD screen, you won't need anything else to complete the experience of watching a movie or playing games. Oh yes, it comes with a gamepad too! Easily configurable, with just a few wires to plug in, this Beanstalk is sure to give you a rollicking time!

